NestSelf authentication and authorization: quick guide

The ten-minute version: what the auth platform does, the decisions behind it and where to look. The detailed walkthrough is `implementation.md`; the full specification with every requirement is `docs/tasks/auth/auth-strategy.md`.

What it does

NestSelf serves five populations from one platform: employees of client companies, their HR and managers, independent experts, NestSelf staff and external suppliers. Each person has exactly one identity for life, may belong to several employers over time, and sees only what their current role allows. Authentication answers "who is this"; authorization answers "what may they do right now, in this organization".

The decisions

Decision	What we chose	Why
Identity provider	Amazon Cognito, one user pool per environment in Frankfurt (eu-central-1)	Email one-time codes, authenticator apps and passkeys without building them; free at pilot scale; EU data residency. Behind an interface so it can be replaced.
Sign-in methods	Employees use an email code. Experts and staff use a password plus an authenticator app. Employers can bring their own SAML or OIDC sign-in (enterprise SSO).	Removes passwords for the largest population; no SMS costs in Serbia and Hungary.
Web sessions	The browser gets an opaque cookie; the API keeps Cognito tokens encrypted in Redis (Backend-for-Frontend)	Tokens never reach JavaScript; revoking a session is deleting a key; CSRF handled with a double-submit token.
Mobile	The app talks to Cognito directly (PKCE) and calls the API with a bearer token	The standard native pattern; tokens live in the device's secure store.
Authorization	Hand-built grants evaluated by a pure `authorize()` function	Delegation, spending ceilings, effective-access previews and a 150-case golden test table are native; tokens carry no roles, so access changes apply within seconds.
Organization structure	A tree of org units with a closure table	Cheap ancestor queries for "manager of this team and everything under it".
Database access	Drizzle ORM with PostgreSQL row-level security	Tenant isolation lives in the database: a query without an organization filter returns nothing. Partial indexes, checks and views are part of the schema.
Audit	Append-only, partitioned `audit_events` with retention tiers	Every consequential action is recorded; nothing sensitive (tokens, message bodies, raw IPs) ever is.
Background work	BullMQ on Redis, run by a separate worker process	Reconciliation (expired grants, stale mobile token families, audit partitions, expired sessions, expired emergency access, expiring SSO certificates) is audited like any user action and never runs inside the API process.

Decision	What we chose	Why
Step-up	Sensitive actions need a sign-in or a fresh email code from the last 5 to 30 minutes, depending on the action's class	Granting access, ending memberships, reading confidential records and emergency access stay safe on an unattended screen. Every class uses an email code for now; the authenticator for the emergency class is an owner decision.
Legacy roles	Removed from the database; every permission is a grant	One source of truth. `db:backfill-grants` converted the old role columns before migration `0005` dropped them.
Organization ownership	Exactly one `employer_owner` per organization: the organization's superadmin, who grants and revokes access and can hand the role to another member. NestSelf staff can change anything for an organization, including transferring its ownership	One accountable person per client, support never locked out. A second owner is refused with 409 `owner_exists`.
Enforcement	Every route declares `@Public`, `@Authenticated` or `@Authorize`; a CI test fails otherwise	Default deny cannot be forgotten.
Rollout	Cognito first, platform stacks later, mobile last	Local development stays local; the CDK app deploys only the auth stack unless asked for more.

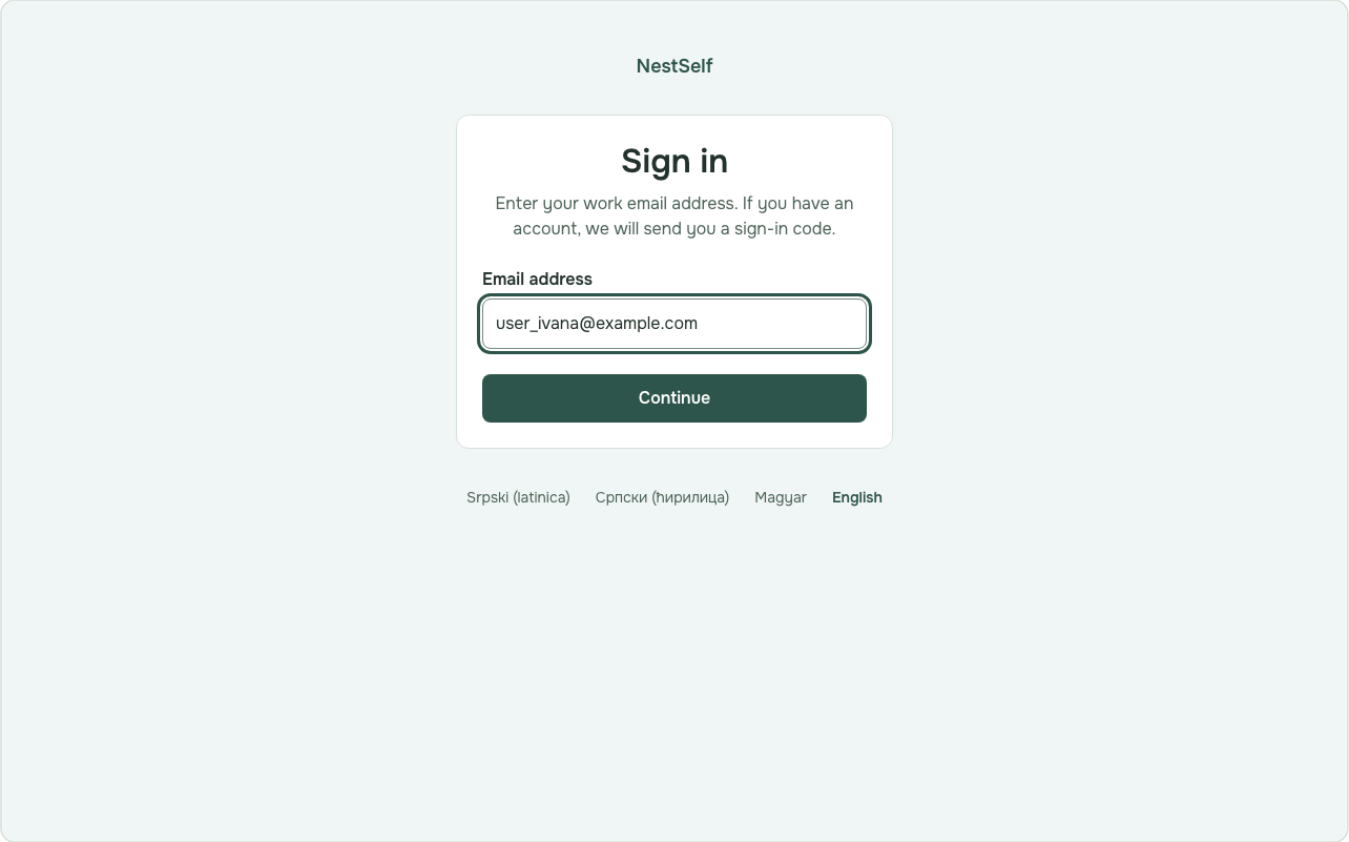
How a request works

1. The browser sends the session cookie (or the app sends a bearer token).
2. `AuthenticationGuard` turns it into a `Principal`: who they are, their memberships, their active context.
3. `CsrfGuard` checks the CSRF header on mutating browser requests.
4. `AuthorizationGuard` reads the route's `@Authorize(action, resolver)`, loads grants and assignments (cached in Redis for 30 to 60 seconds), and asks `authorize()`. Denied requests get 404 when the caller should not even know the record exists, 403 otherwise. For a sensitive action it also checks that the caller authenticated recently enough and answers 403 `step_up_required` if not.
5. The handler runs its writes inside an organization-scoped transaction; PostgreSQL row-level security blocks anything outside that organization.
6. Consequential actions are written to the audit log; access changes publish an invalidation that drops caches and disconnects affected WebSocket clients.

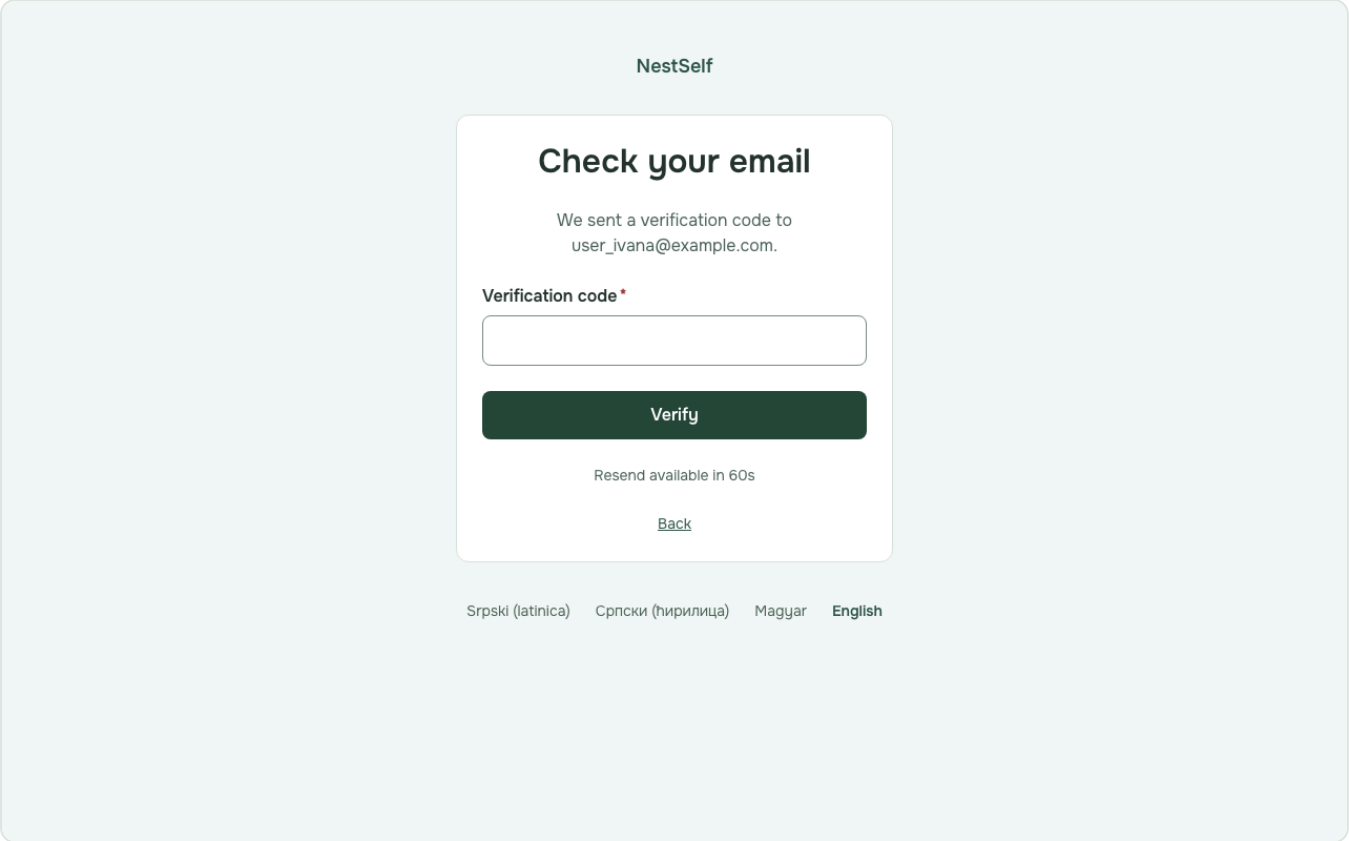
How sign-in works

- **Employee**: enter email → receive an **eight digit** code (Cognito's length, not configurable) → enter it → session cookie. A wrong code can be retyped on the same challenge up to three times; after the third the user requests a new code, and five wrong codes in total lock the address for 15 minutes (`implementation.md`, section 6). The code email is written in the language of the sign-in screen.
- **Expert or staff**: enter email → password → authenticator code (first time: scan a QR code) → session cookie. Invited staff set a password first.

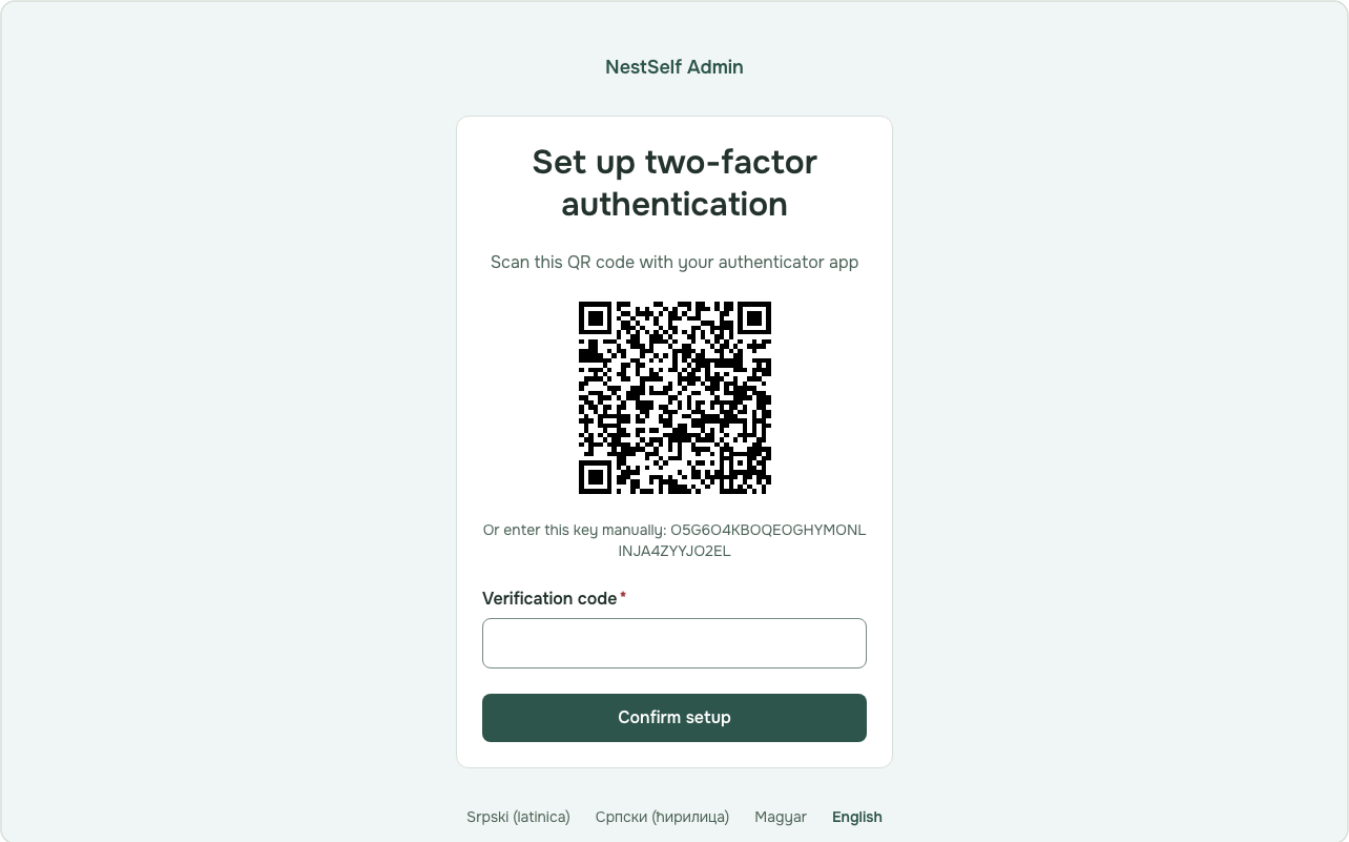
- **Invitation**: HR invites by email; the link previews the organization name and activates the membership on acceptance, then runs the matching sign-in.
- **Mobile**: email code directly against Cognito; the app refreshes tokens itself and uses short-lived tickets to open WebSockets.



Workspace sign-in: one field first; the address decides the method.



Employees then type the code from the email.



Staff and experts enrol an authenticator on their first sign-in to the admin app.

Enterprise SSO

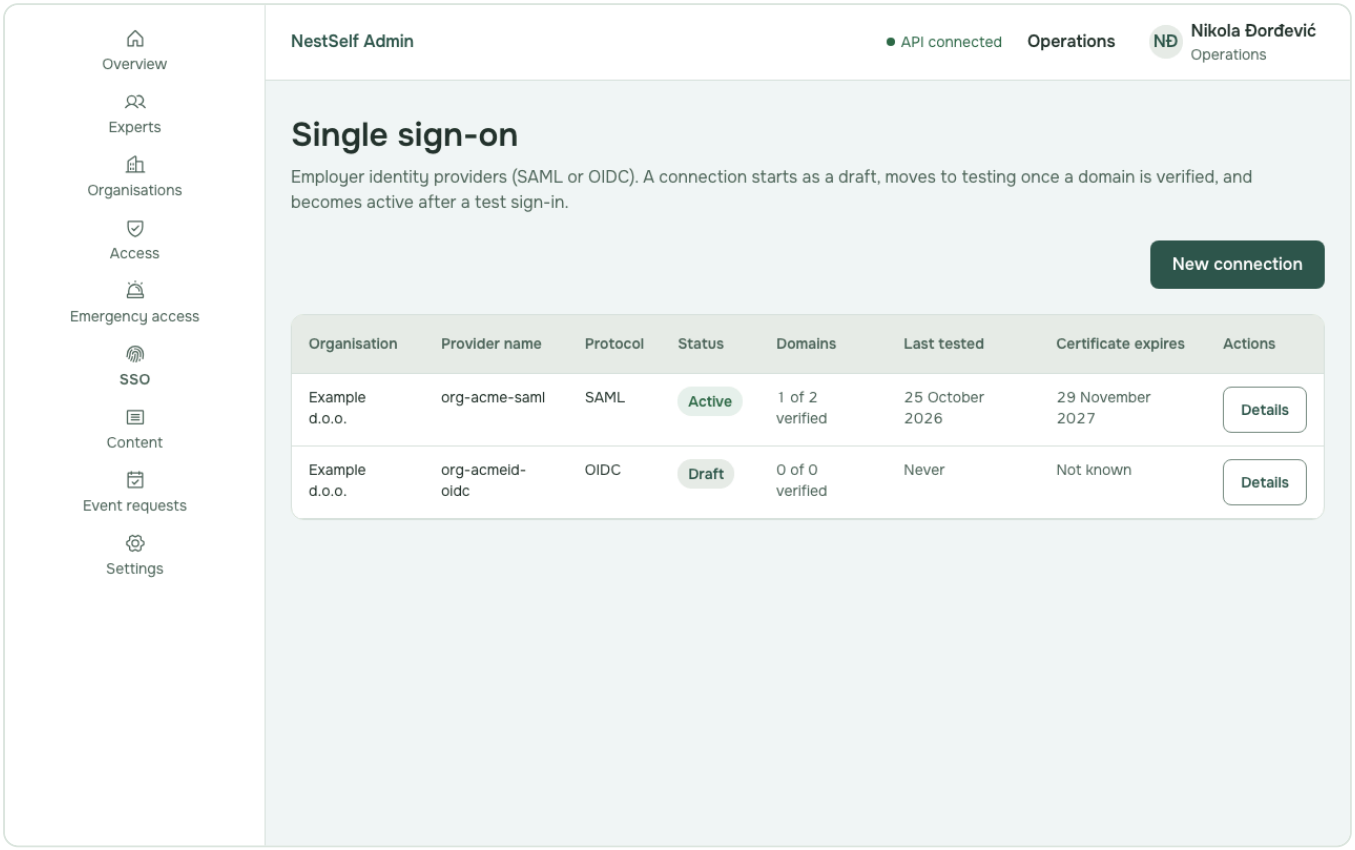
An employer can let its employees sign in through its own identity provider (SAML 2.0 or OIDC). Only sign-ins that start at NestSelf are accepted; the employer's portal cannot push people in.

What staff do (admin `/sso`, platform owners, every change after a recent sign-in or step-up):

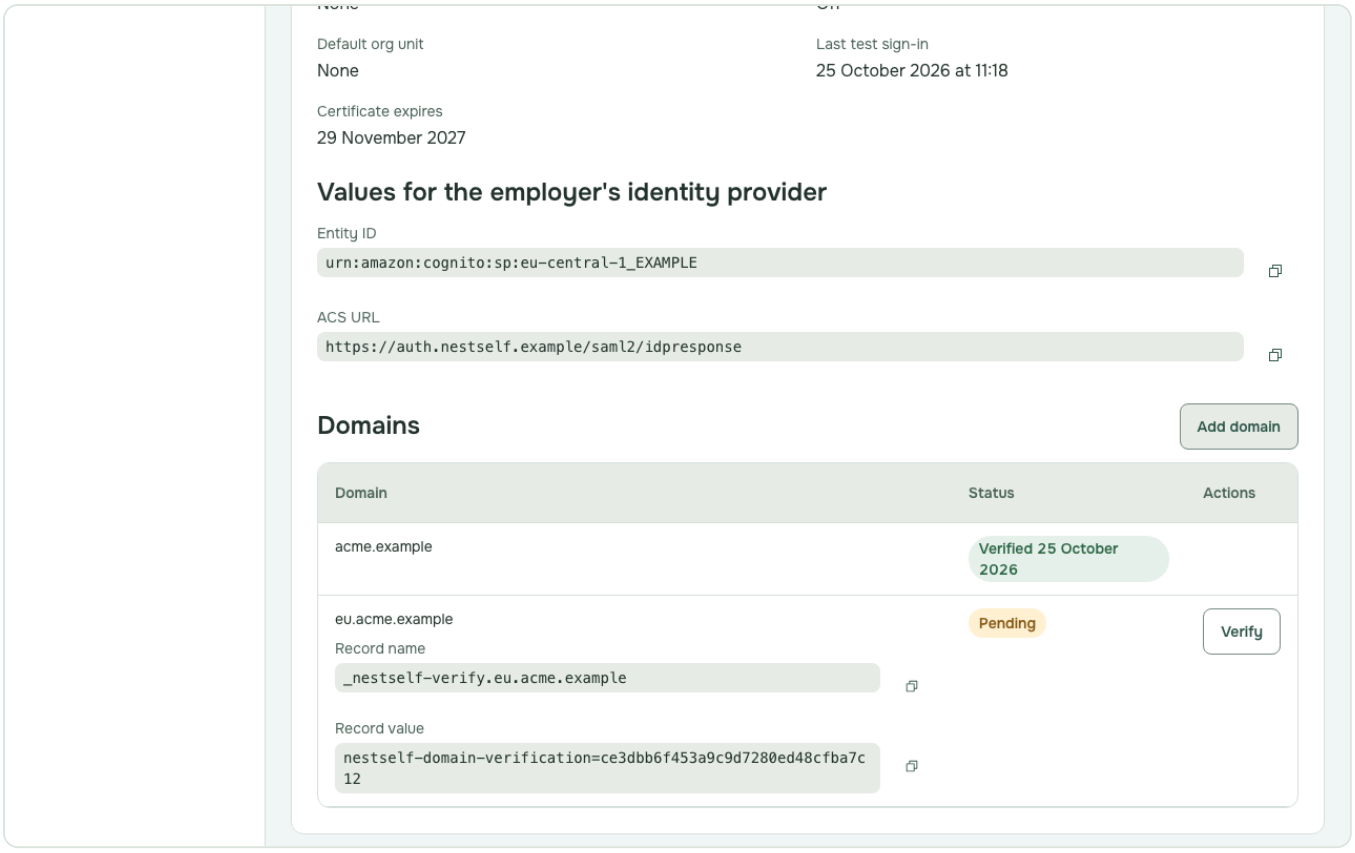
1. Create the connection for the organization: a slug (it builds the provider name, for example `org-acme-saml`) and the employer's metadata, or the OIDC issuer, client ID and secret. The secret goes straight to Cognito and is never shown or stored by NestSelf. A slug belongs to one organization: another organization cannot take it, for either protocol. The connection starts as a draft.
2. Add the employer's email domains. Each gets a DNS TXT record (`_nestself-verify.<domain>`) that the employer publishes; then select Verify. Public mail domains such as `gmail.com` are refused.
3. Hand the employer the entity ID and ACS URL from the detail panel, then select Test sign-in. The link works once and for 15 minutes; an invited test person on a verified domain signs in with it.
4. Activate. From then on, discovery sends that employer's addresses to their sign-in. Suspend sends them back to the email code. Changing the provider settings of an active connection (metadata, issuer, client ID or secret) takes it back to testing: run a new test sign-in and activate it again.

What an employee sees: they type their work address on the normal sign-in screen, see "Redirecting to your organisation's sign-in…", sign in at their employer and land in NestSelf. NestSelf binds the account only for a pending invitation of that organization (or automatic accounts, if the employer turned them on), and only for an address on one of the connection's verified domains. Anyone else sees a neutral "Your organisation has not enabled your account yet" message. The employer's sign-in counts as the second factor.

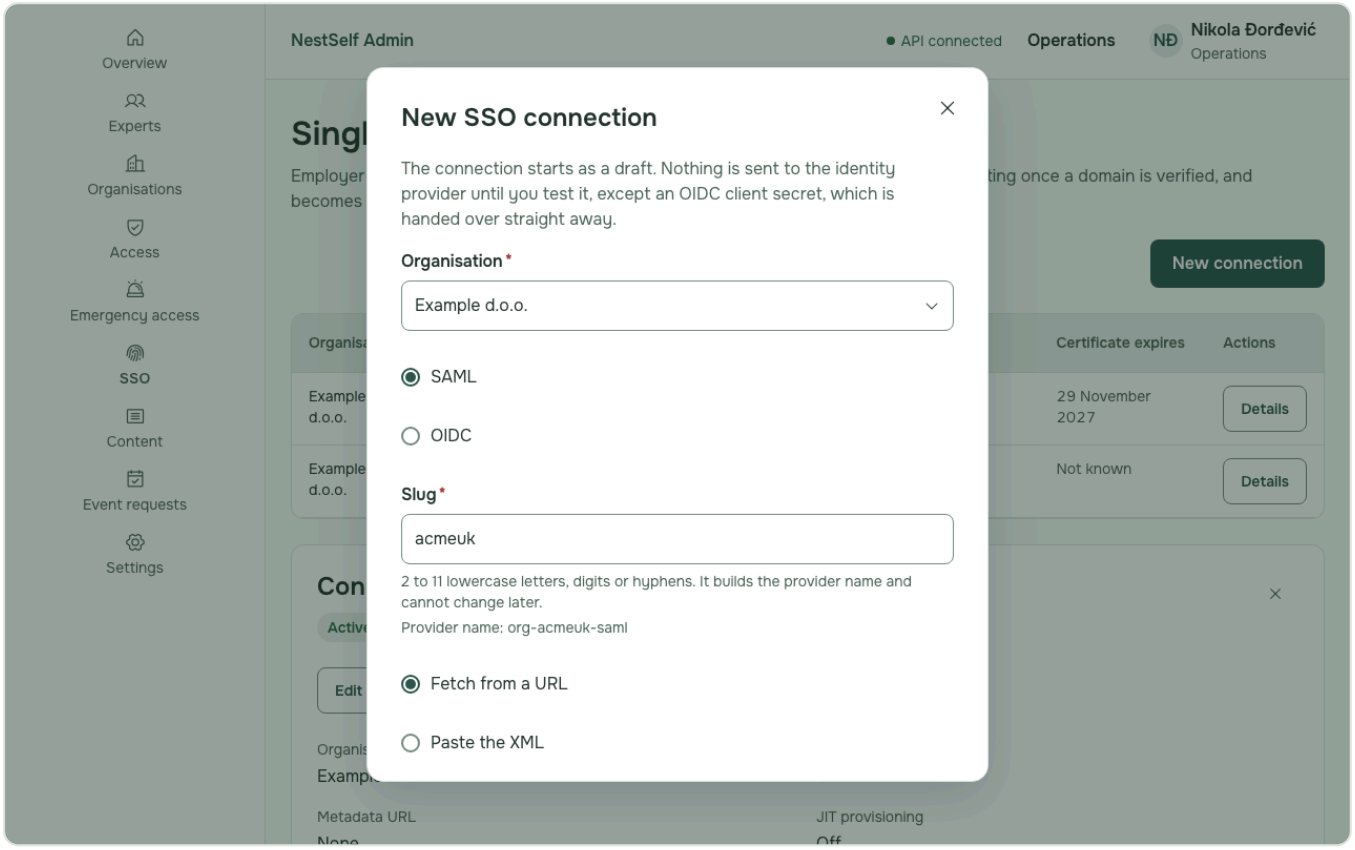
A nightly job warns (audit row and log line) when an employer's signing certificate expires within 30 days.



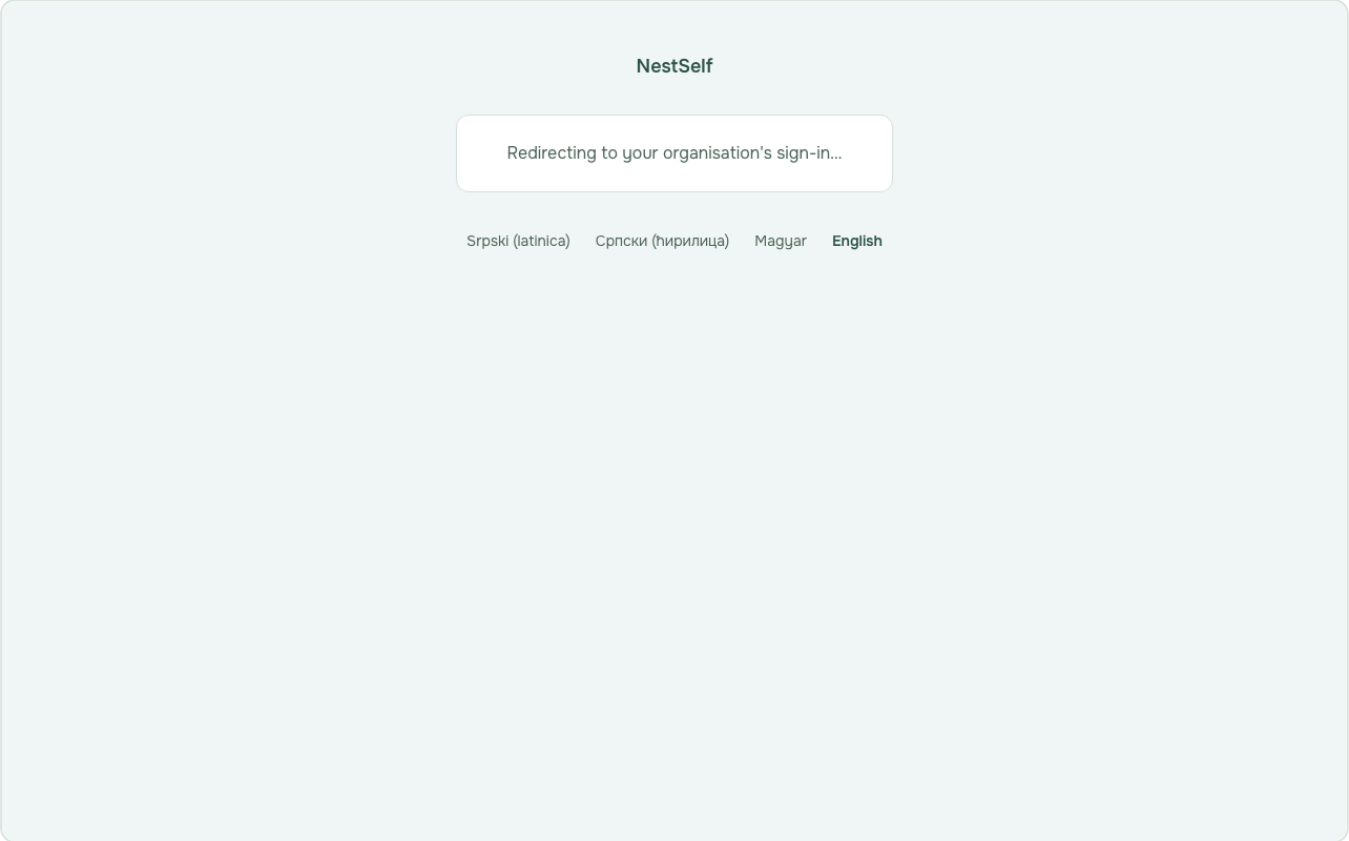
Staff: the SSO connections of the fictional sample organization, created through the stub API for the screenshot.



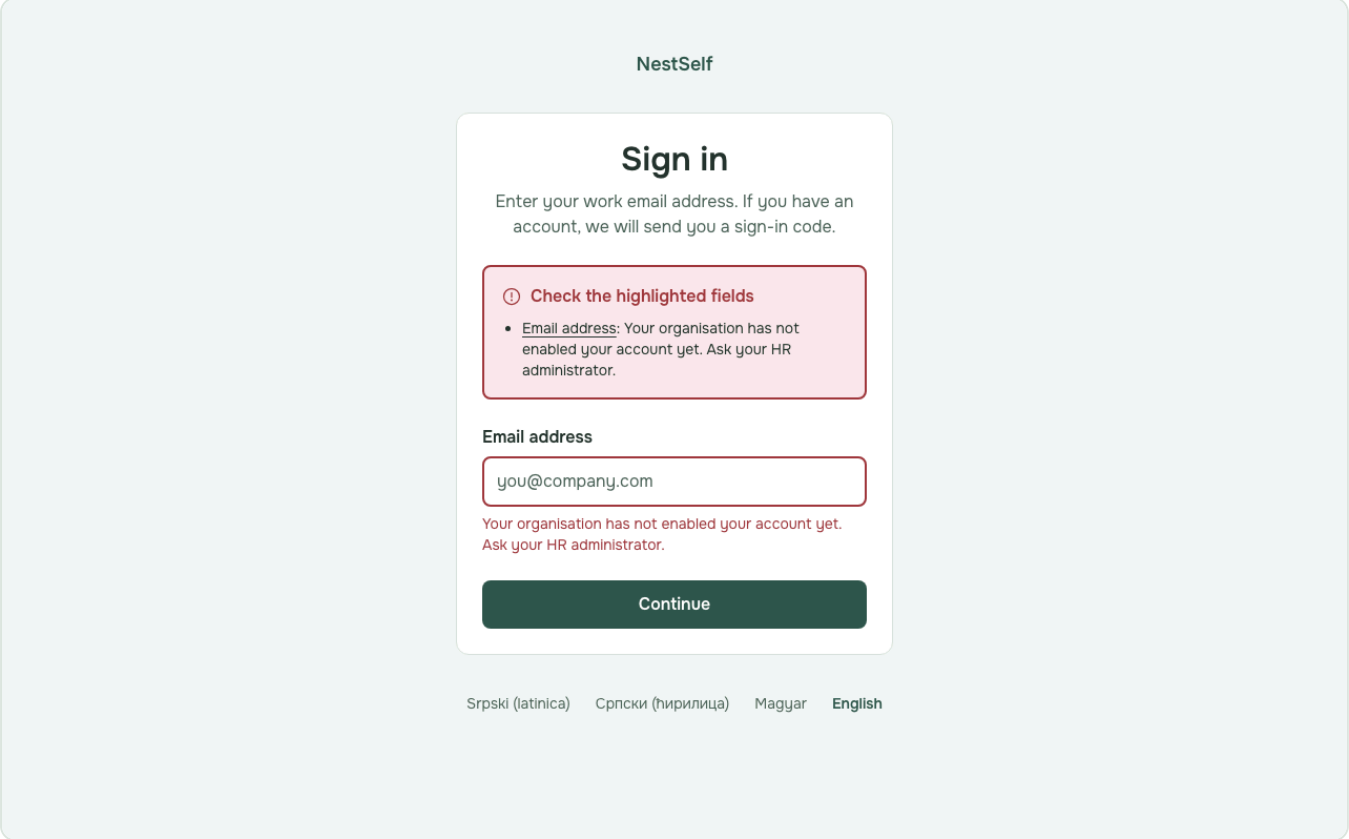
Staff: a connection's values for the employer and its domains; the pending one shows the TXT record to publish.



Staff: the create dialog, cancelled.



Employee: discovery recognised the employer's domain. For the screenshot the browser was kept from leaving the page.

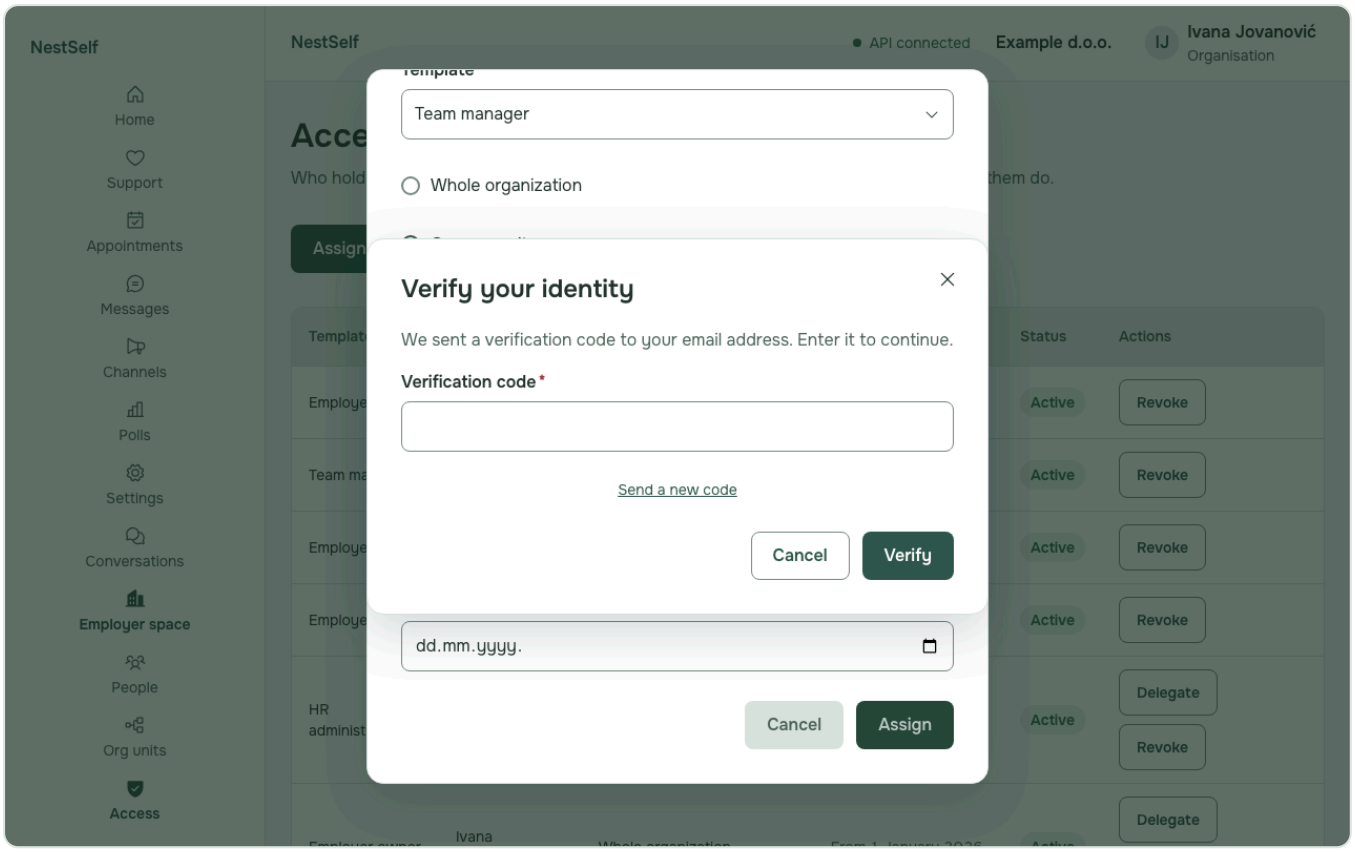


Employee: the employer signed the person in, but NestSelf had nothing to bind them to.

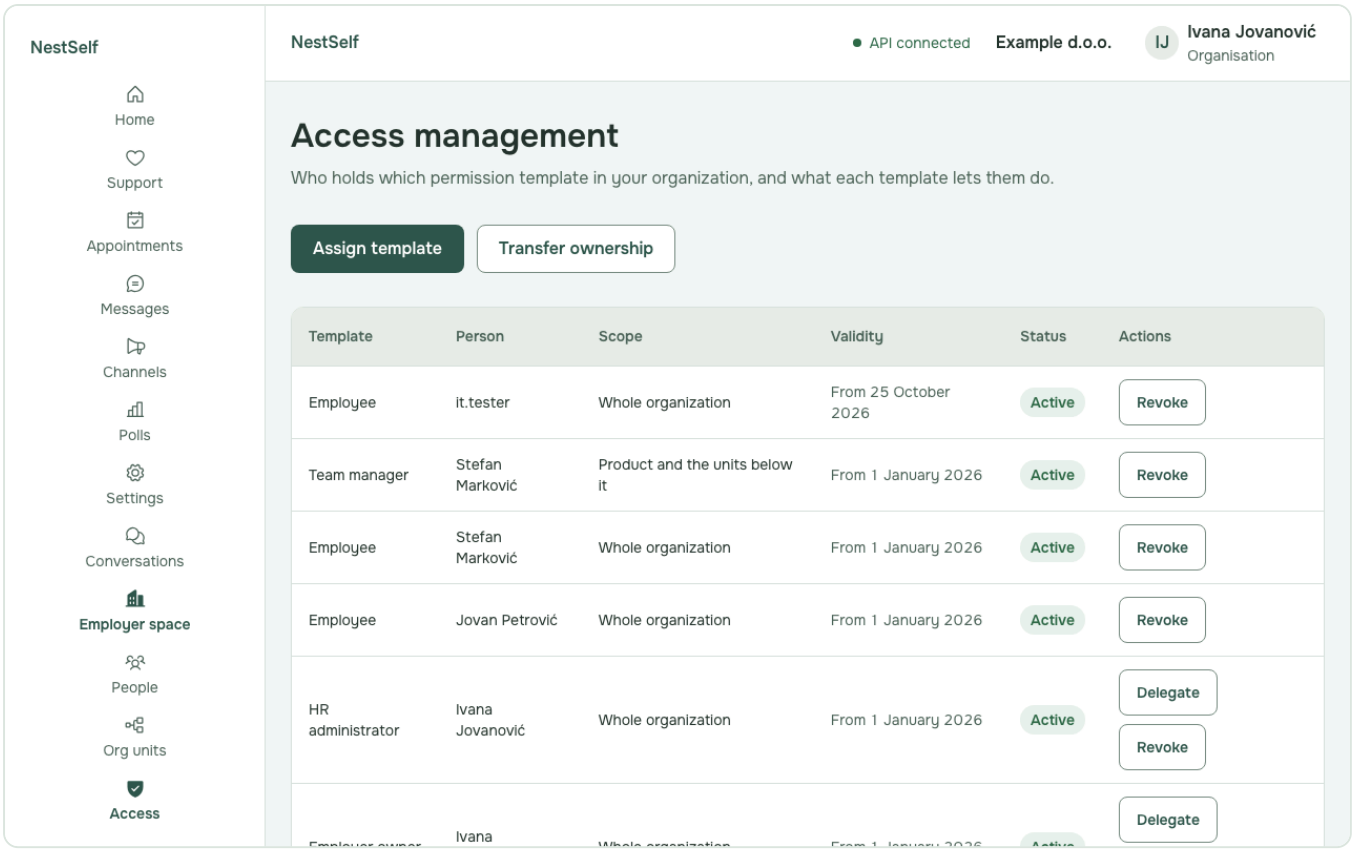
Everything is tested locally against a fake identity provider; the test against a real employer IdP waits for a pilot employer (`implementation.md`, section 22).

Step-up and the access screens

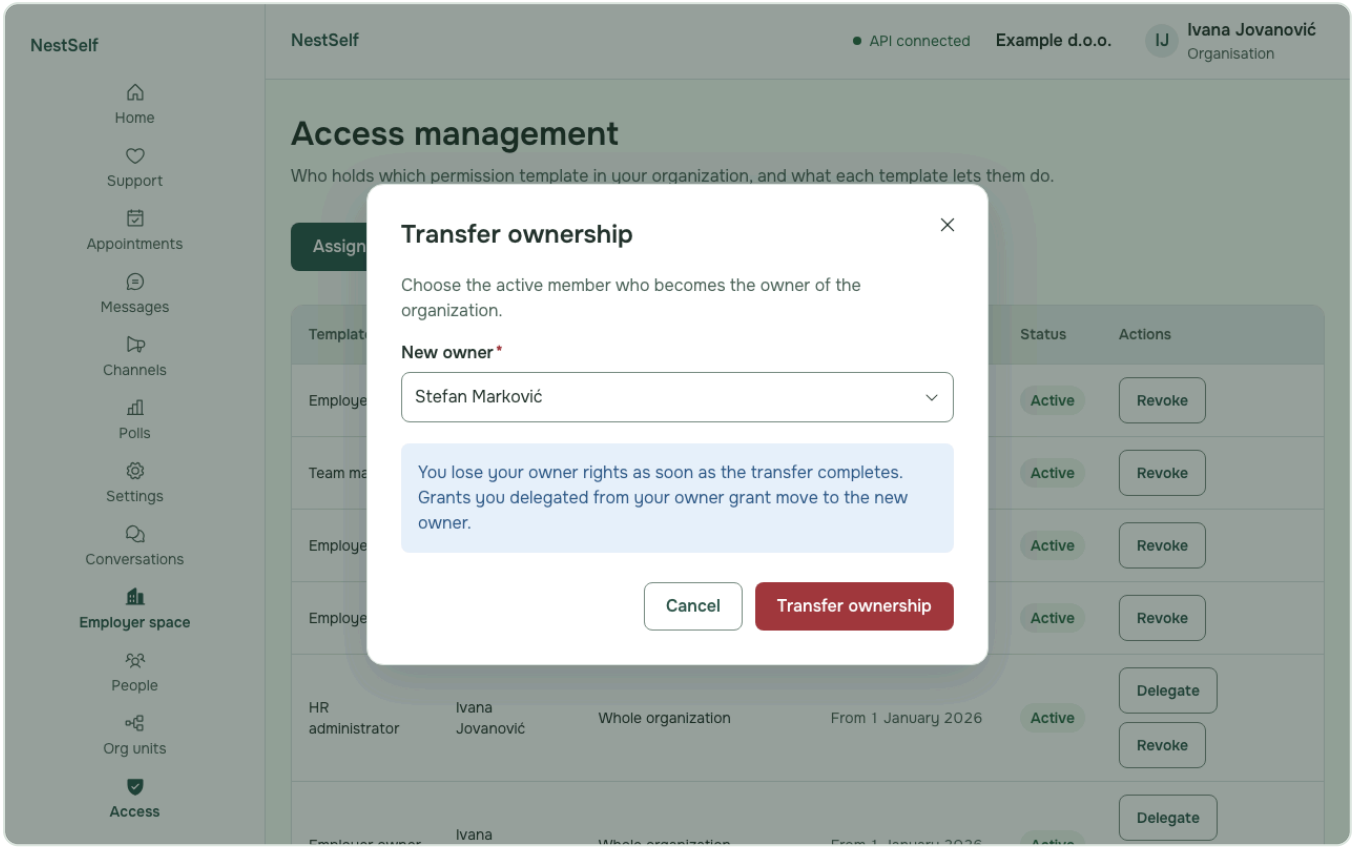
- **Step-up**: when the API answers `step_up_required`, the web apps open a dialog, email a fresh code and retry the action once the code is accepted. Cancelling leaves the action undone without an error. Wrong codes follow the same three-tries rule as sign-in. Mobile has no step-up screen yet.
- **Workspace, `/hr/access`**: for the organization's owner (the sample Ivana, who is also its HR administrator). Shows the organization's grants, previews any member's effective access, assigns and revokes templates, delegates part of one's own grant and transfers ownership to another active member.
- **Admin, organization Access tab and `/access`**: for platform owners. Assigns organization templates to an organization's members (organization-wide; org-unit grants are HR's job), transfers an organization's ownership (also when it has no owner yet), assigns staff templates, revokes grants and looks up any user's access per context.
- **Sample mode** shows the same screens over fixtures with every change disabled.



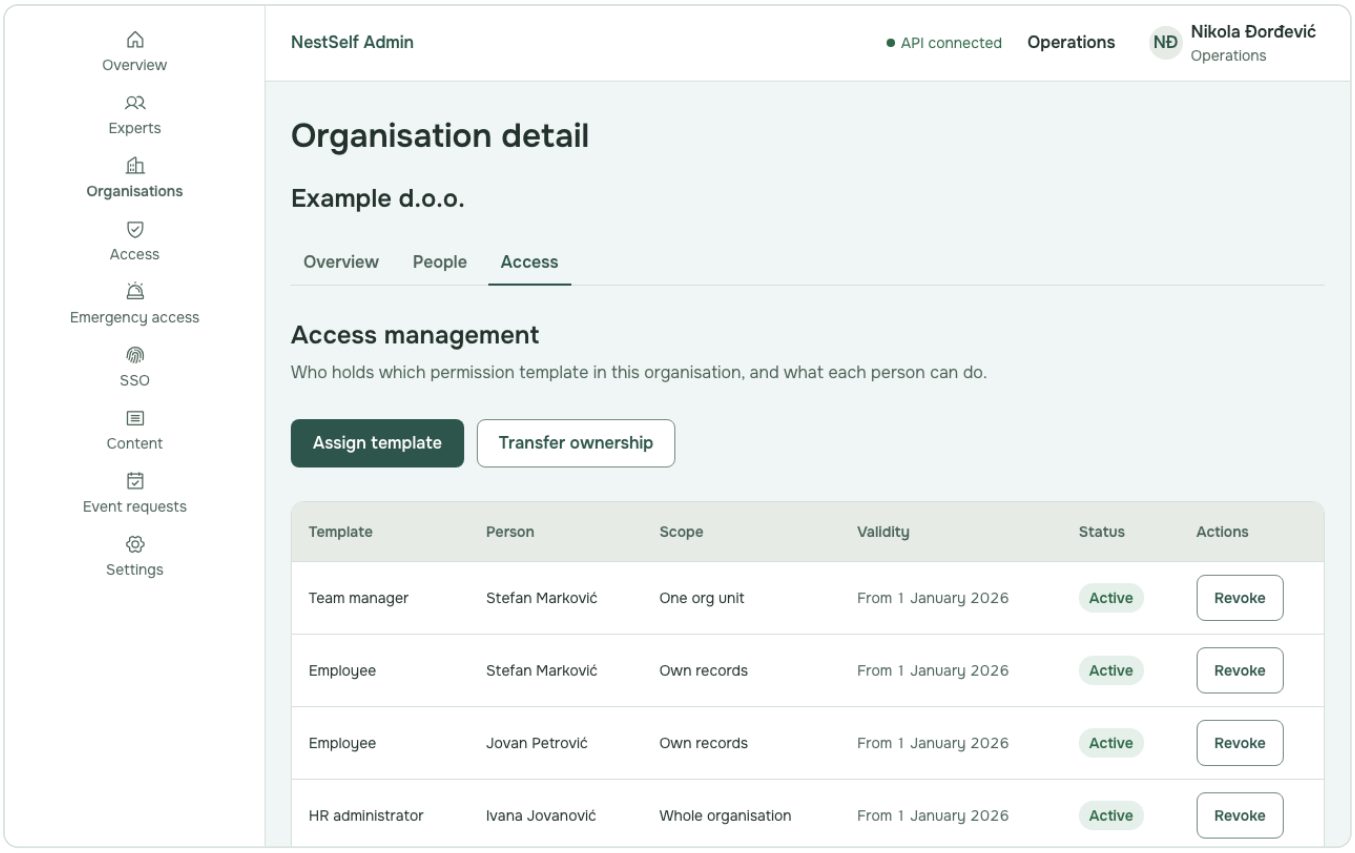
Step-up: a fresh email code before a sensitive change, here an assignment.



Workspace `/hr/access` for the owner.



Transfer ownership: only the current owner sees it; the old owner's delegations move to the new owner.



The same organization seen by staff in the admin app.

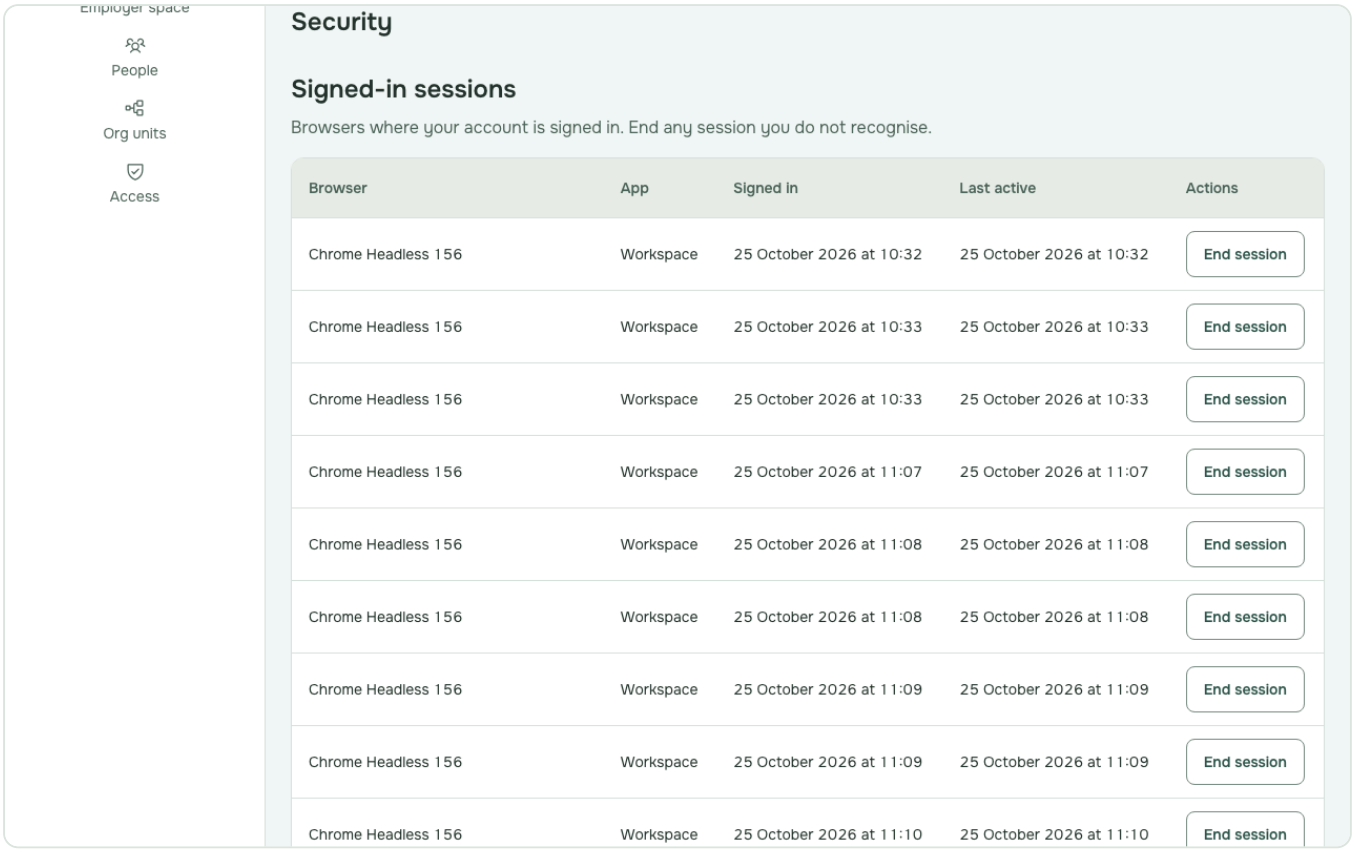
The screenshots are of the real screens against the stub API with the fictional sample people; `pnpm docs:auth:screenshots` regenerates them (`implementation.md`, section 19).

What each role can do and where

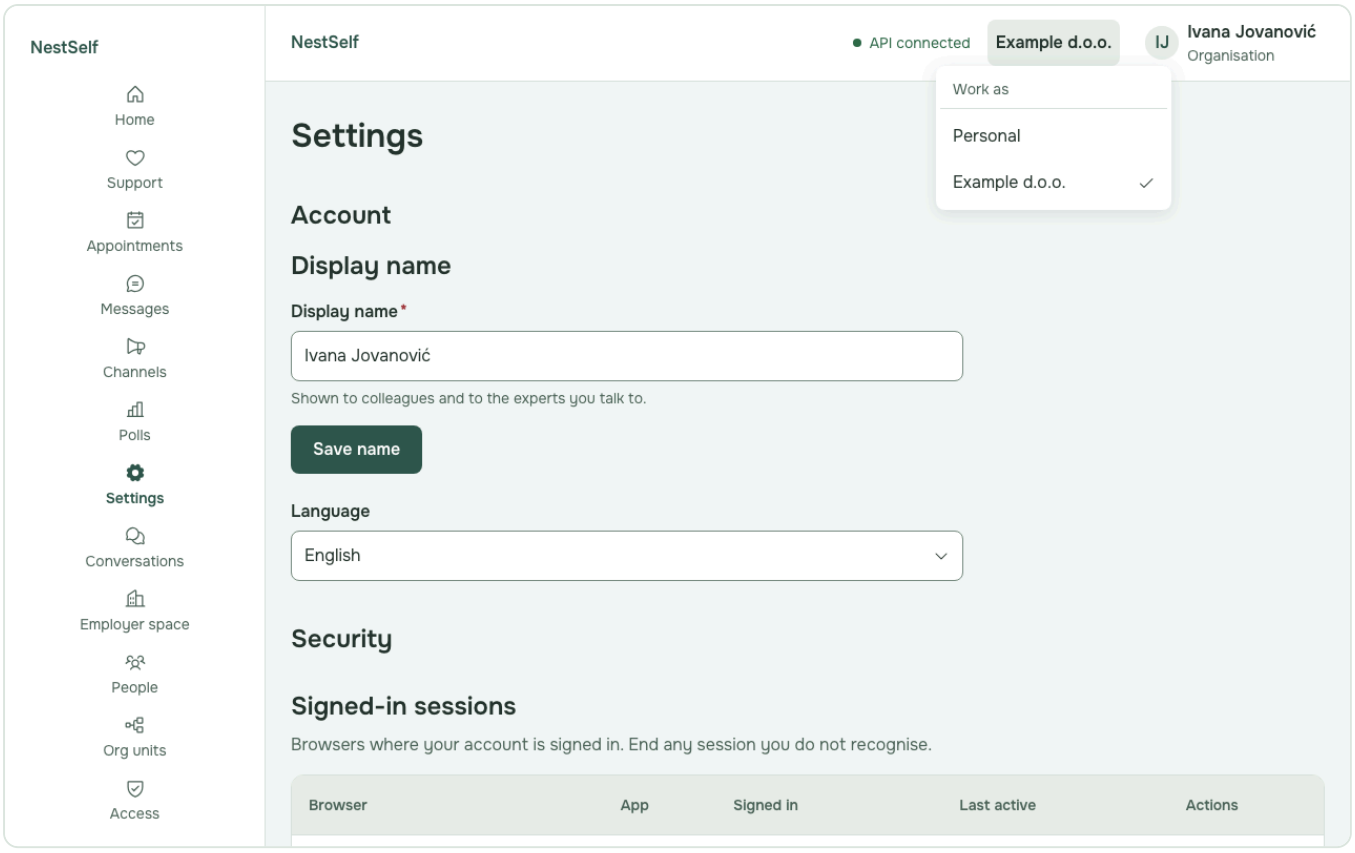
Every auth capability of the API has a screen in the web apps since 2026-10-25 (`implementation.md`, section 3.1, maps each one to its route, gate and API). The screens hide what a role cannot do, but the API decides: hiding a button is a convenience, never the check. Everyone signed in has `/settings` (display name, language, signed-in sessions, sign out everywhere, and the authenticator for password users), the account menu with Sign out, and the context picker in the header when they have more than one context.

Role	What they can do	Where
Owner (`employer_owner`, one per organization)	Grant, revoke and delegate access, preview anyone's effective access, transfer ownership	Workspace `/hr/access` (the sample owner is also HR admin; the route sits under the HR area)
HR admin (`hr_admin`)	See members, move them between org units and line managers, end memberships; invite, import and revoke invitations; add, rename and move org units	Workspace `/hr/people` (Members, Invitations) and `/hr/org-units`
Manager (`team_manager`)	Their team's budget, events and approvals; their own account and sessions	Workspace manager area and `/settings`; no access administration

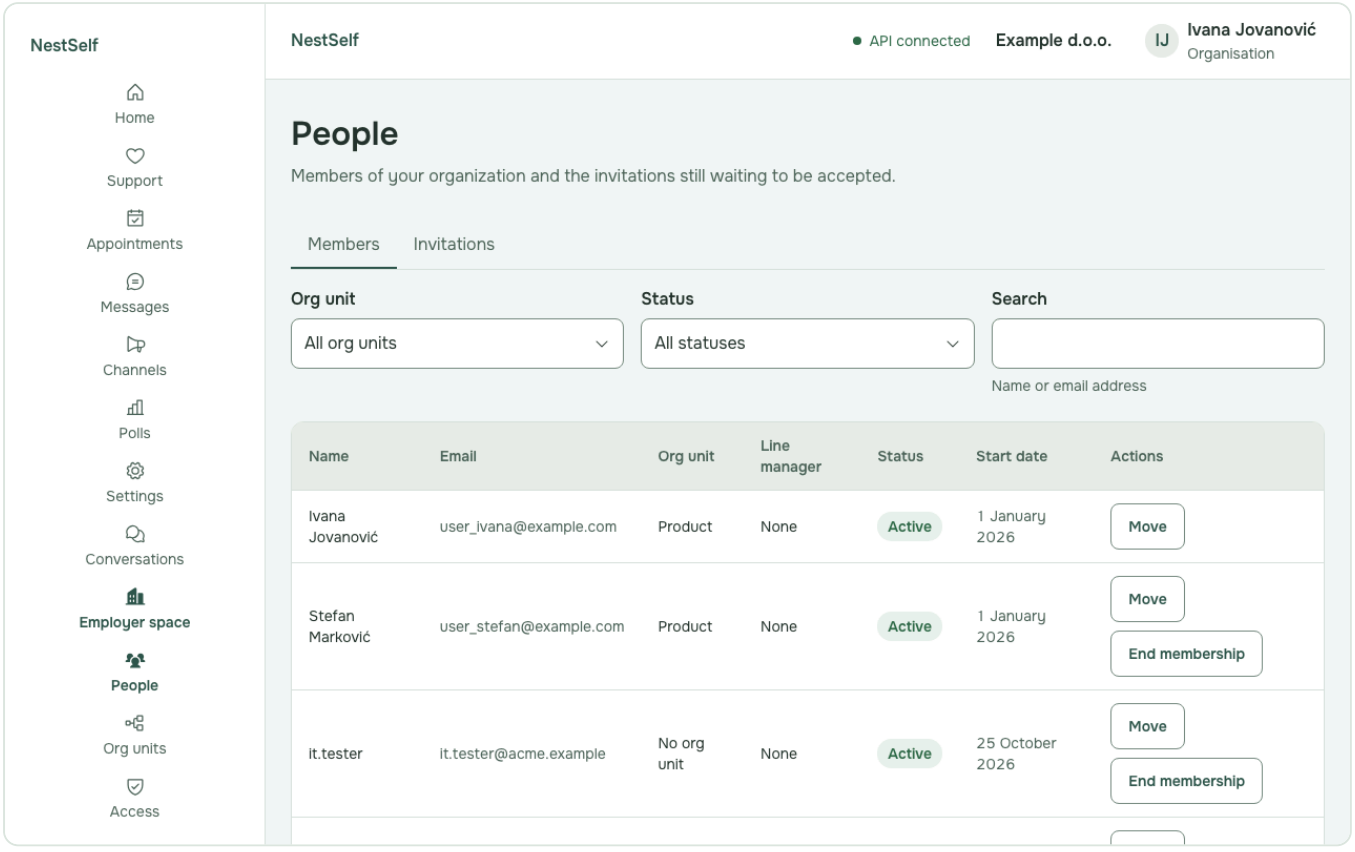
Role	What they can do	Where
Employee (`employee`)	Their own conversations with an expert, read-only; their account and sessions; switch between personal and organization contexts	Workspace `/conversations` and `/settings`
Expert (`expert`)	Read the conversations of the cases assigned to them (a fresh sign-in or step-up within 15 minutes) and the intake record	Workspace `/cases` (switches them to the expert context)
Staff: platform owner (`platform_owner`)	List organizations, see an organization's members and end memberships, set or transfer its owner, manage platform and organization grants, look up any user's access, suspend and reinstate users, request, approve, deny and revoke emergency access and read a record under it	Admin `/organizations` , `/organizations/:orgId` (Overview, People, Access), `/access` , `/emergency`
Staff: platform owner, SSO (`sso.manage` , held by `platform_owner` only)	Register, verify, test, activate, suspend and edit an employer's SSO connection	Admin `/sso`
Staff: client operations (`client_operations`)	For assigned clients only: members, invitations and imports, end memberships	Admin `/organizations/:orgId/people` , opened by link (the list is platform-wide only)



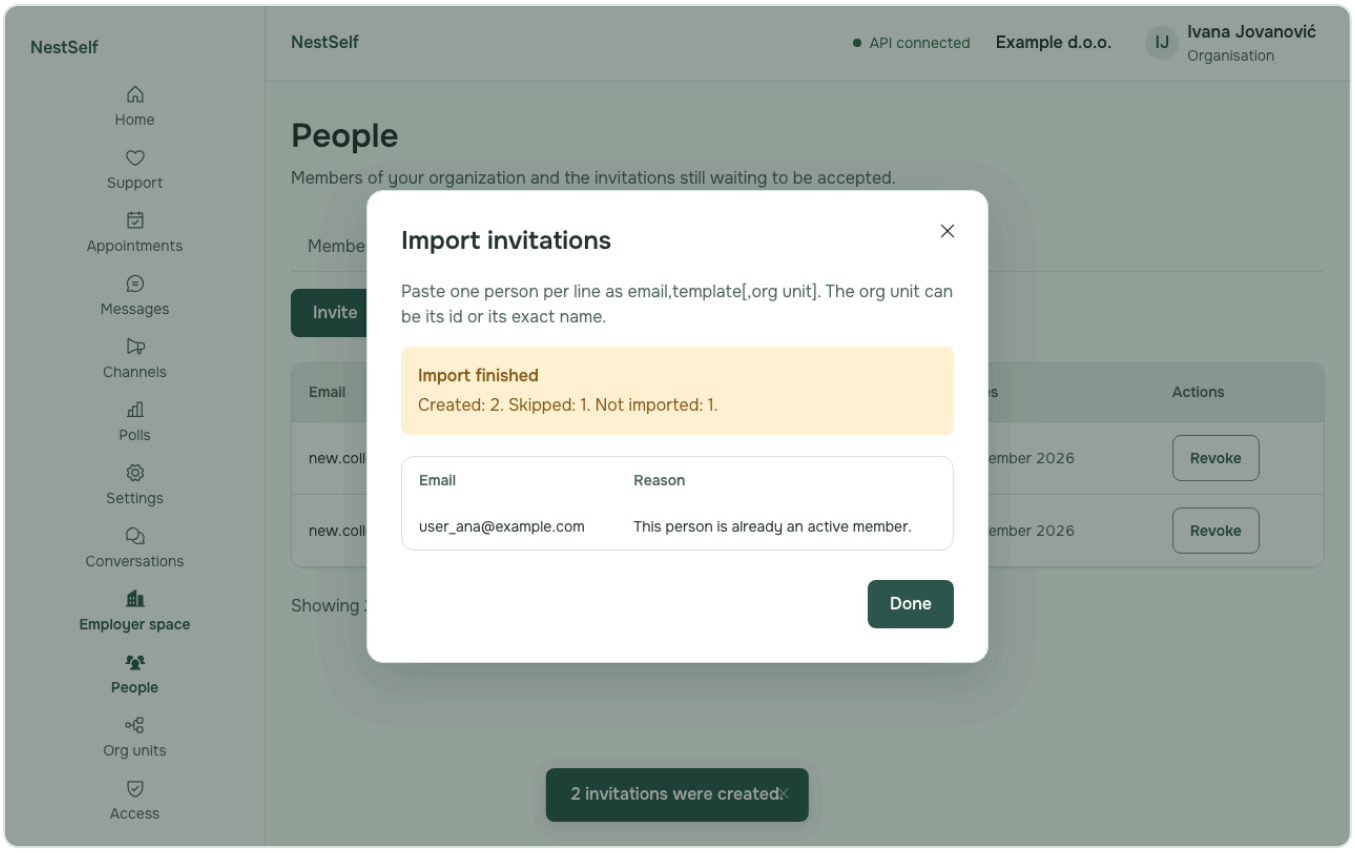
Everyone: the signed-in sessions in `/settings` , with Sign out everywhere.



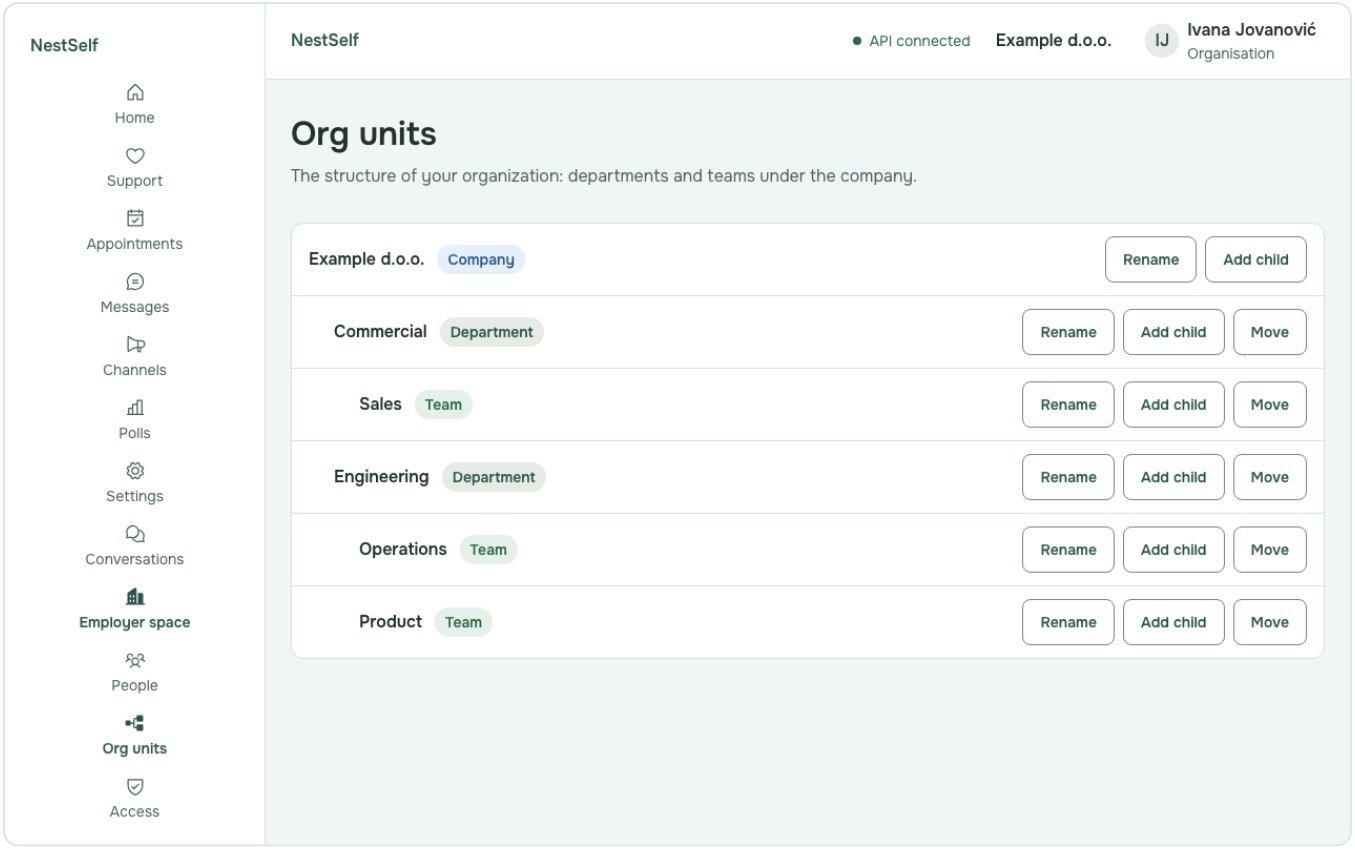
Everyone with more than one context: the picker in the header switches between personal and organization (and expert or operations where held).



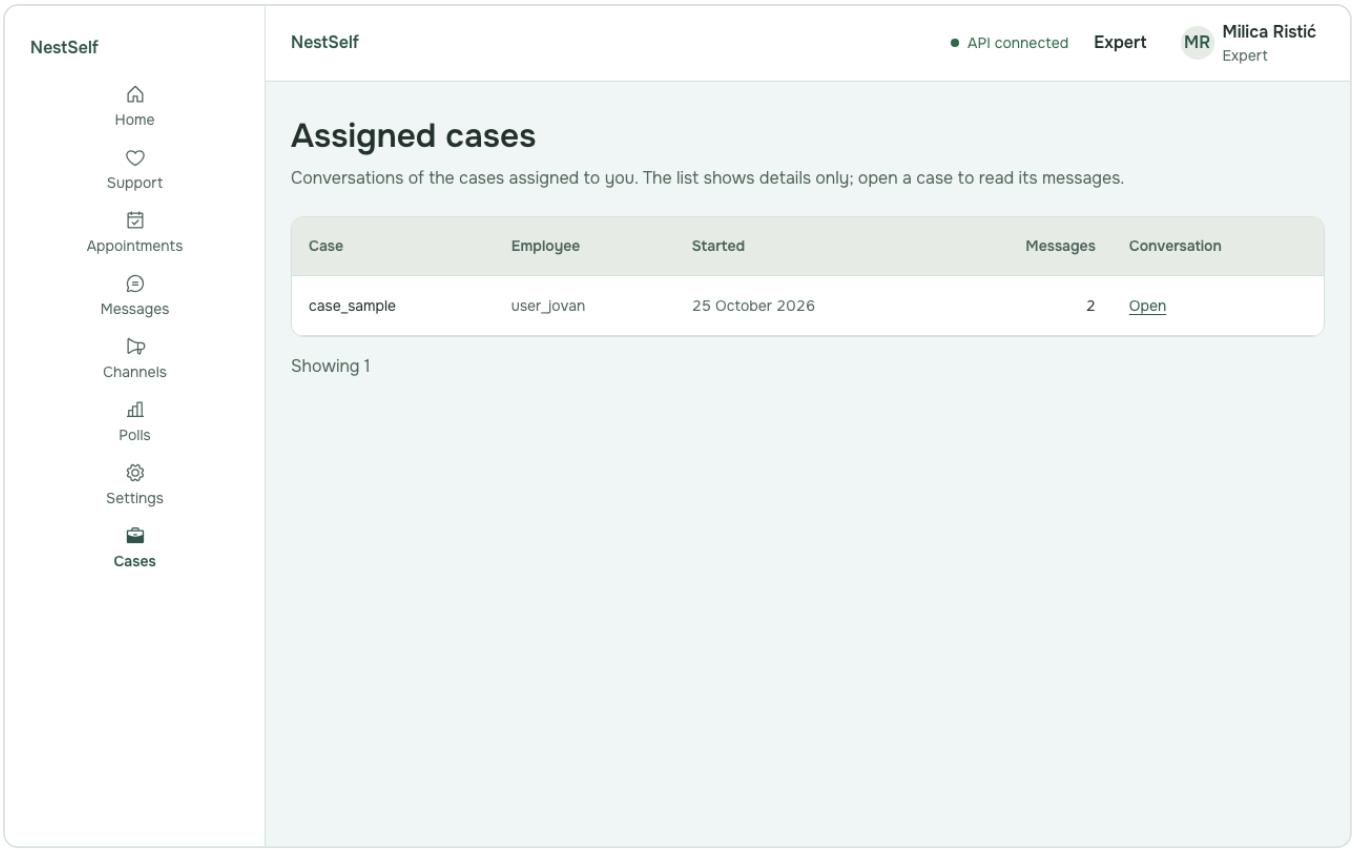
HR admin: `/hr/people`, members with Move and End membership.



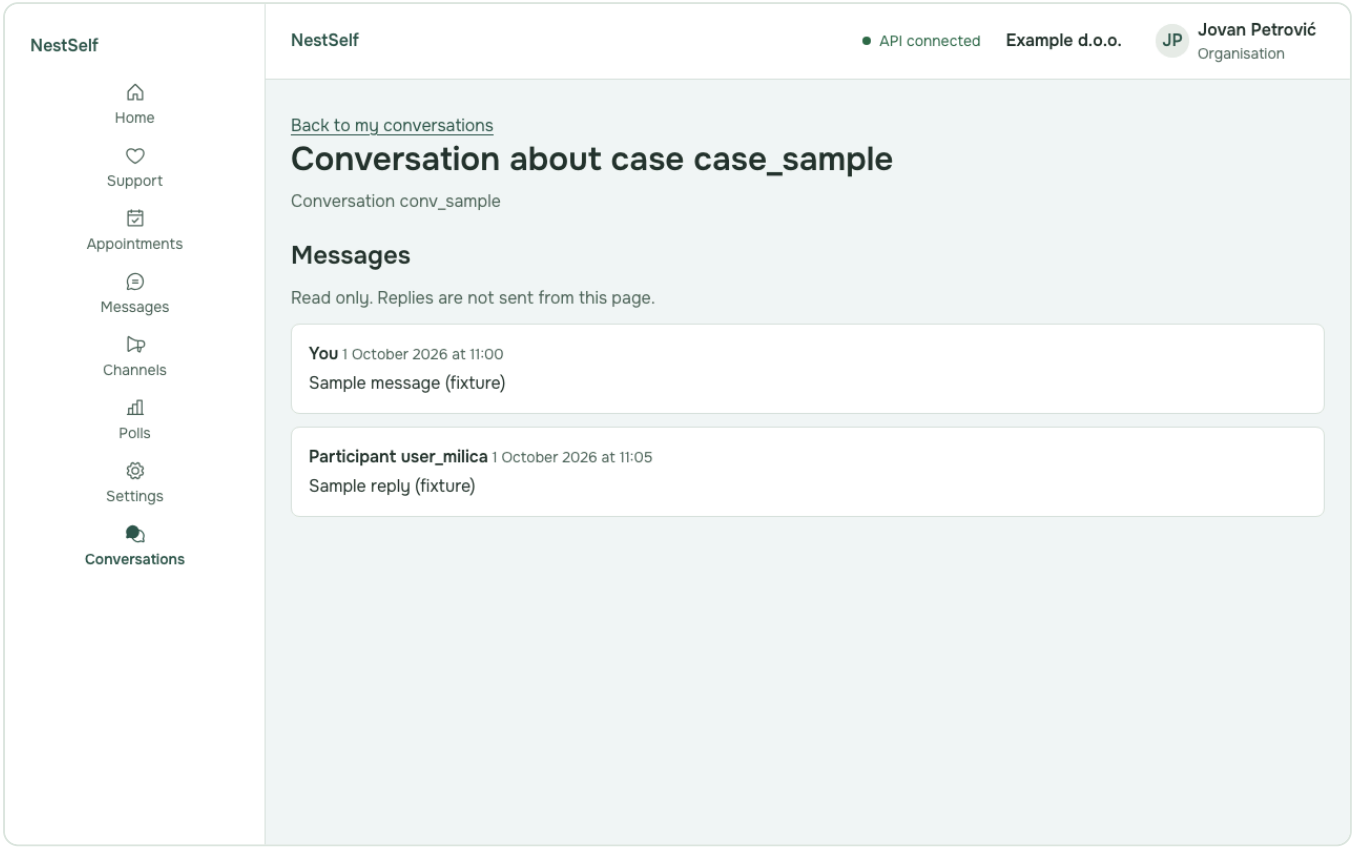
HR admin: importing invitations from pasted lines, with the rows the server refused and why. The two invitations were created in the disposable e2e database for the screenshot.



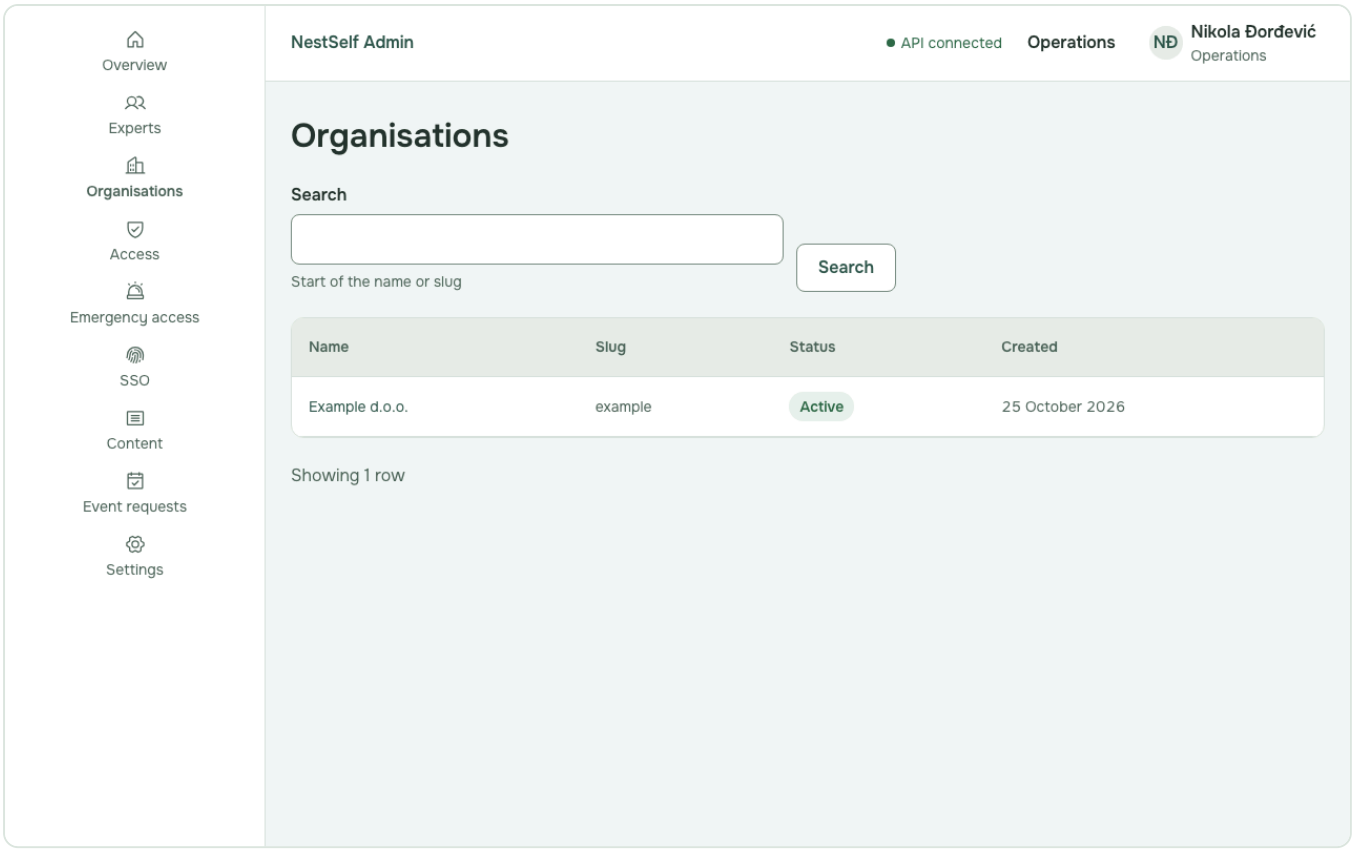
HR admin: the org-unit tree with Rename, Add child and Move.



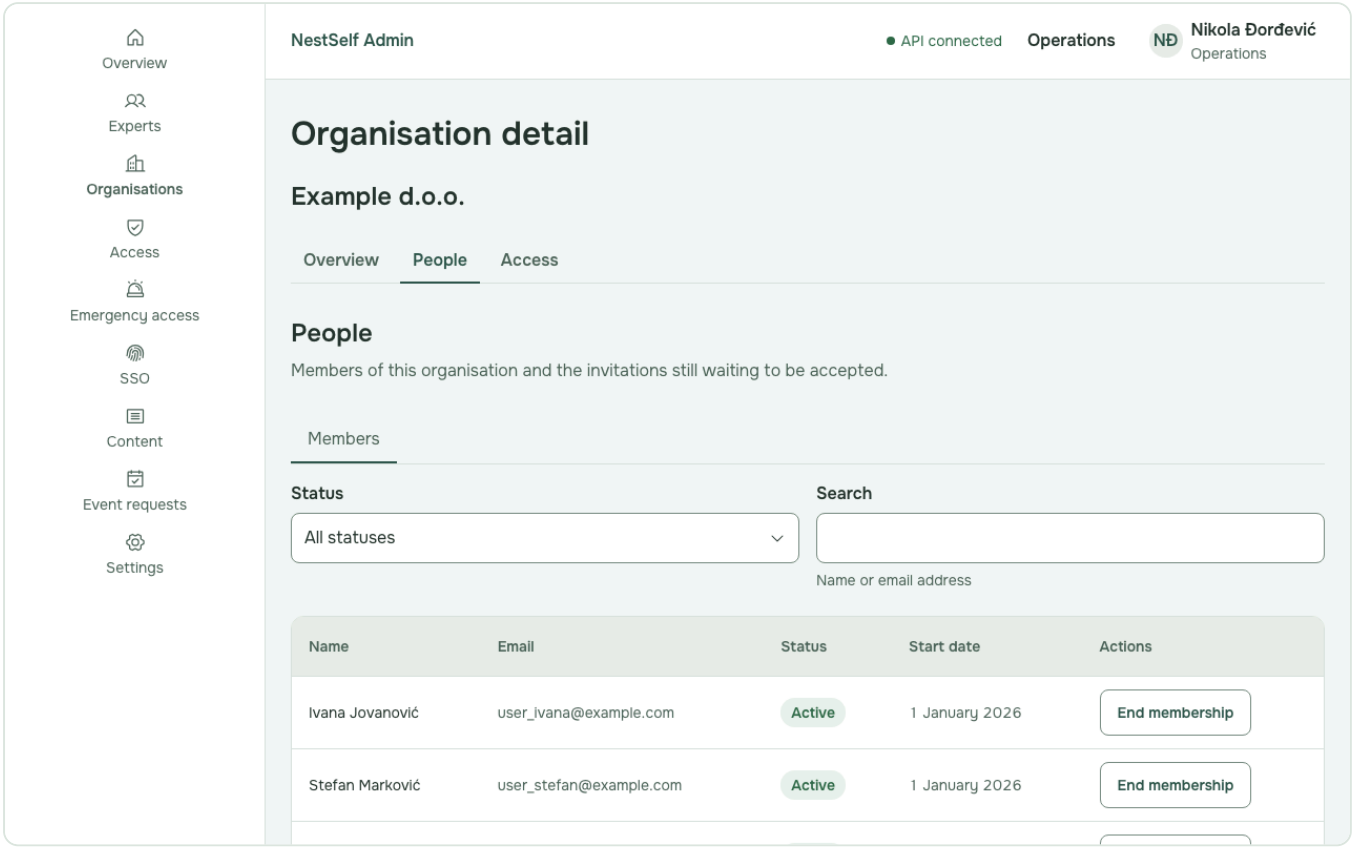
Expert: the conversations of assigned cases.



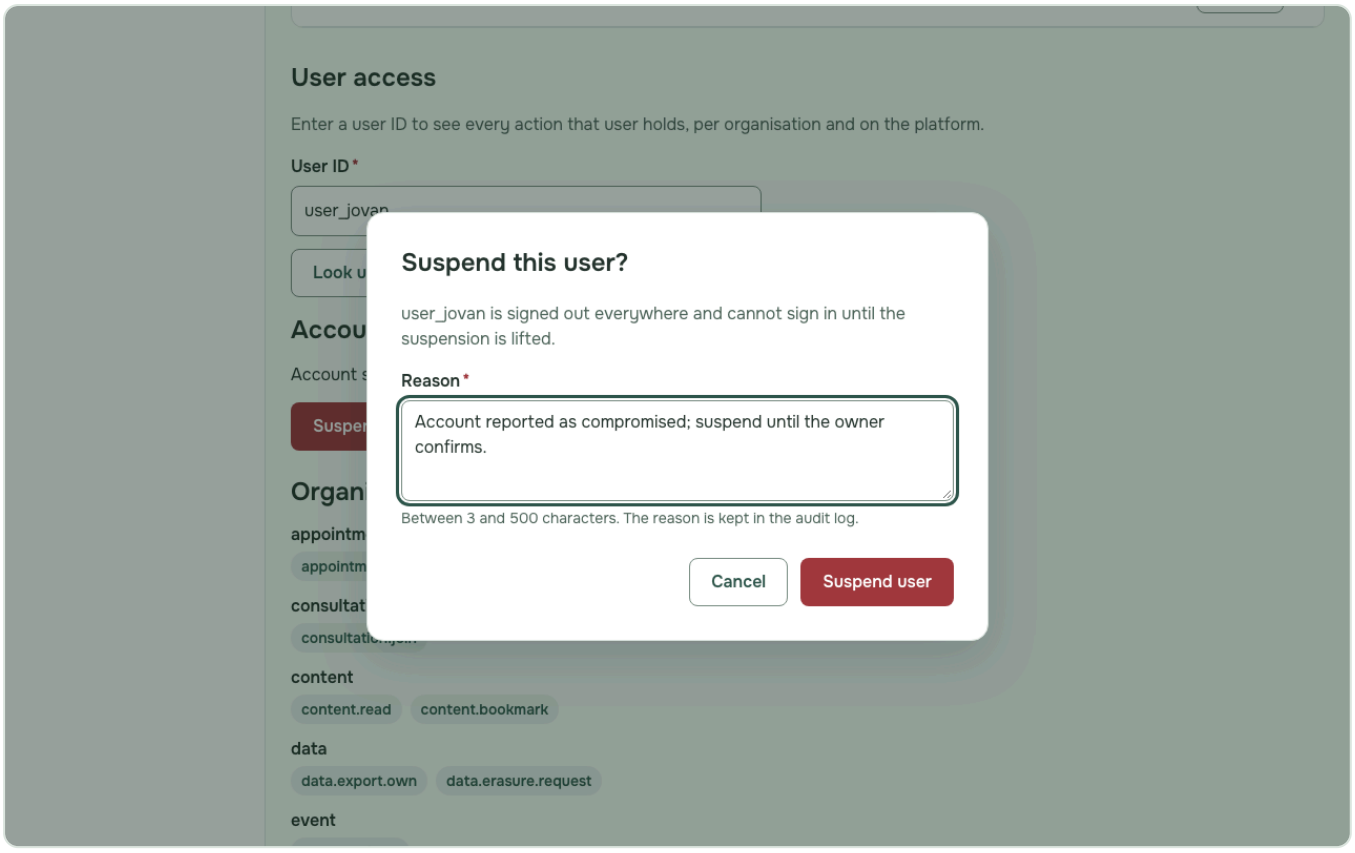
Employee: their own conversation, read-only.



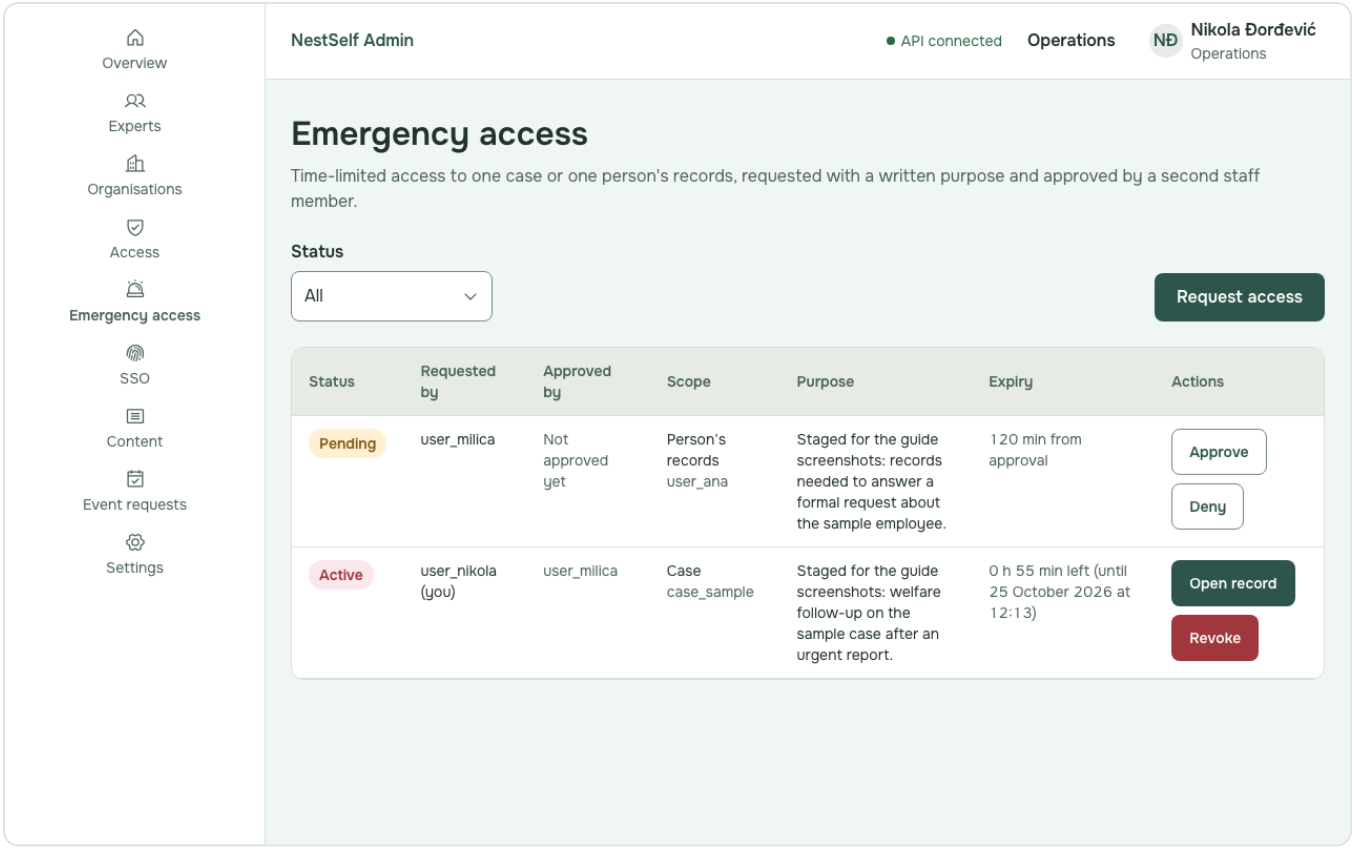
Staff: the organizations list.



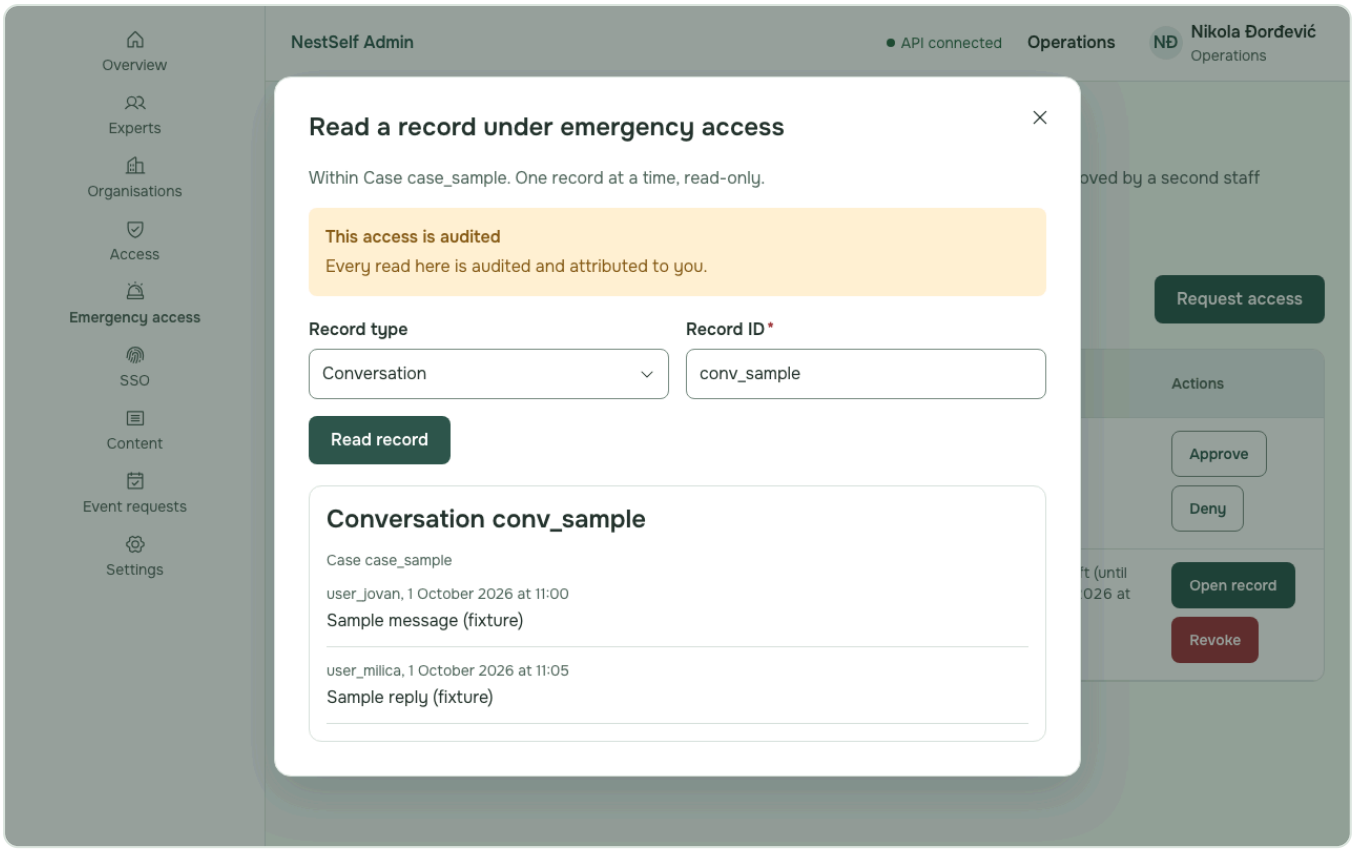
Staff: an organization's members.



Staff: suspending a user from the access lookup asks for a reason; one's own account cannot be suspended.



Staff: emergency access. Approve and Deny appear only on someone else's request; the rows were staged for the screenshot.



Staff: reading a record under approved emergency access, with the audited notice.

Where to look

Question	Place
Which routes exist and which decorator they carry	`apps/api/docs/auth-core.md`
The guards and sign-in services	`apps/api/src/auth/`, `apps/api/src/authz/`
The decision engine and its golden table	`apps/api/src/authz/authorize.ts`, `golden-table.json`
Actions, templates, shared schemas	`packages/contracts/src/`
Database schema, migrations, seed	`apps/api/src/db/schema/`, `apps/api/drizzle/`, `apps/api/src/db/seed/`
Sessions and Redis keys	`apps/api/src/session/`, `apps/api/src/redis/redis-keys.ts`
Sign-in screens	`apps/workspace/src/auth/screens/`, `apps/admin/src/auth/screens/`, `apps/mobile/src/auth/`
Cognito infrastructure and rollout steps	`CDK-setup.md` (repo root), `infra/cdk/lib/auth-stack.ts`, `infra/cdk/README.md`
Nightly jobs and the worker process	`apps/api/src/jobs/`, `apps/api/src/worker/main.ts`

Question	Place
Grant administration, confidential reads, emergency access	`apps/api/src/grants/`, `apps/api/src/professional/`, `apps/api/src/emergency/`
Step-up	`apps/api/src/auth/step-up.service.ts`, `apps/api/src/authz/step-up-freshness.ts`, the web apps' `src/auth/step-up-dialog.tsx`
Access screens	`apps/workspace/src/features/access/`, `apps/admin/src/features/access/`
Settings, people, org units, organizations, emergency, expert screens	`apps/{workspace,admin}/src/features/` (`account`, `context`, `people`, `org-units`, `organizations`, `users`, `emergency`, `cases`); the full map is `implementation.md` section 3.1
Browser journeys and screenshots	`e2e/auth/`, `e2e/screenshots/`, `e2e/README.md`
Enterprise SSO	`apps/api/src/sso/`, `apps/api/src/auth/sso-callback.service.ts`, `discover.service.ts`, `apps/api/src/identity/cognito-sso-ops.ts`, `apps/admin/src/features/sso/`, `implementation.md` section 22
Phase 2 and 3 status and what is left	`docs/tasks/auth/phase-2-readiness.md`, `implementation.md` section 21
Environment variables	`docs/environment.md`, `apps/api/src/config/env.ts`

Running it locally

```
pnpm install && pnpm db:up
cp apps/api/.env.example apps/api/.env
pnpm --filter @nestself/api db:migrate && pnpm --filter @nestself/api db:seed
pnpm --filter @nestself/api dev
pnpm --filter @nestself/api worker:dev   # optional: jobs, needs REDIS_URL (runs through the
Nest compiler)
```

Stub mode uses a fake identity provider pre-loaded with the sample people. Employees (`user_jovan@example.com`, `user_ivana@example.com`, `user_stefan@example.com`, `user_dragan@example.com`) sign in with the code printed in the API log, and Ivana reaches `/hr/access`; staff and experts (`user_nikola@example.com`, `user_milica@example.com`) use the password `Nestself-dev-1234!` and enrol an authenticator on first sign-in. Set `VITE_DATA_SOURCE=api` in a web app's `.env.local` to use the real screens. Skip `pnpm db:up` when PostgreSQL and Redis already run outside Docker; the Compose file claims port 6379 and fails against a local Redis or Valkey.

A real Cognito dev pool exists since 2026-10-24 (`eu-central-1_g6OGYONQ0` in account `634972095709`). Set `AUTH_MODE=cognito` with the values `infra/cdk/scripts/env-from-outputs.mjs dev` prints, and note that pool usernames are email addresses, not handles. `implementation.md` section 17.1 has the deployed coordinates and the three traps worth knowing before touching it.

Glossary

- **Principal**: the resolved identity for a request (user, memberships, active context, how they authenticated).
- **Context**: the hat the user wears right now: personal, a specific organization, expert, or operations.
- **Grant**: a user's permission to perform actions within a scope, with conditions and a validity window.
- **Template**: a named starting set of actions (`hr_admin`, `team_manager`, `employee`, ...) grants are created from.
- **Assignment**: a link to a work item (case, queue, client) that confers access without a grant.
- **Closure table**: every ancestor to descendant pair of the org tree, so scope checks are a set lookup.
- **Step-up**: re-authenticating recently before a sensitive action; enforced by the API.
- **Delegation**: handing part of one's own grant to another member, at most three levels deep and never beyond the parent grant.

What is not done yet

For enterprise SSO: the live test with a pilot employer's IdP, binding the account after the email code when the employer did not confirm the address, SSO on mobile, step-up for SSO users, the certificate alert email, IdP-initiated sign-in and SCIM (`implementation.md` section 22.14). Beyond SSO: mobile step-up, the remaining nightly jobs (Cognito user export, retention sweeper, audit export), file and export authorization, the security baseline that waits for staging, and the compliance track (privacy notices, processing agreement, breach procedure), which must land before the first real employee signs in. Screens for approval authorities and for changing a grant's conditions are still missing; the rest of the auth capabilities have screens (mobile keeps sign-in, settings and sign-out). Open owner decisions: the authenticator for emergency step-up and a `cases` table before anything writes conversations. Who administers grants inside an organization was decided on 2026-10-24: the single employer owner, and NestSelf staff. The full list is `implementation.md` section 21; the status per task is `docs/tasks/auth/phase-2-readiness.md`.